

# Fullness of Power, Joy, and Judgment in the Early Church

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How many would know that we would be on Ananias and Sapphira?

In this teaching, there were two things in the early church that we have not really seen since, at least not to that magnitude.

One was the fullness of power they operated in. We will touch on that. How would you like to bring all who were demon possessed and all who were sick, and have some man of God, some apostle or something, walk out and every single one of them be healed and delivered?

When is the last time you saw that?

So there were two things in position. One was that something came that transformed them like that. Second was the absolute manifestation of the fullness of His power. And the third thing present was instantaneous judgment. Not after a long time, but instantaneous. They would speak it, and it would happen.

The reason it happened was not that God is a respecter of persons. It happened because He found what He needed to do it with when the mantles came to absolute fullness in the establishment of the early church.

The third part I had been trying to catch and was not quite catching, I finally caught. What caused all those Jews, three thousand the first day of Pentecost, and after the lame man over forty years old was healed, another five thousand added that day?

There had to be nine, ten, eleven, twelve thousand Jews in Solomon's porch just living, worshipping, considering nothing their own, sitting day and night at the feet of the twelve who had slept and eaten with Jesus and heard every parable He ever spoke.

Day and night, they considered nothing their own.

I thought, What is the fullness of that? I wanted to know. If the miracles were at their fullest, if all the demon possessed from the cities round about were healed at their fullest, what else was at its fullness?

What could cause a bunch of people like that to give everything they had with no fear?

Finally, that anointing that swept in in Brazil and touched down, I have never seen anything quite like it. When it touched me, it did something on the inside of me.

What came to fullness was no fear, no insecurities. The only place I have been able to find that is where that extreme joy is. "The joy of the Lord is my strength." Perfect love casts out fear. "This is My peace."

When that touched down on me, I could very easily declare nothing my own with absolutely no fear.

So now I know that His joy was also to the fullness. If there is anything that ever gets God's people to do anything, this is it. We have tried to preach them into it and threaten them into it, but I am telling you, there is a place in His joy where total surrender is accomplished.

You cannot stand it in the middle of everything.

The joy of the Lord is what? My strength.

If it is my strength, what is trying to come and take it? How about a celebration when nothing is trying to be taken from you, much less when it is?

Good land.

We knew they had all things in common. We knew they saw miracles they had never seen before. We knew the mantle on them was at its fullness. We knew judgment was instantaneous.

That is why Peter was able to judge Ananias and Sapphira. He found what he needed to do it with.

Was it a special act of God? No, it was not. If God can reestablish that mantle, then you are going to see a whole lot of special acts of God in these last days as the church is getting ready to go home.

Let me ask you a question. Recently there was a ministry in town that believed a certain way and finally came forward with it. He had a big exodus from his church, went controversial, and was marked by several preachers in town because he began to preach an all-inclusive gospel, that everybody will be saved when it is all over.

So the only benefit of being saved is that you can pray, walk with God, and have answered prayer. For the sinner, he has to wait until he dies, and then all redemption is done, and God will resurrect him.

Do you know what would have happened to him if Peter or Paul was in town? There would be a lot of people who would not believe that right now.

How far would that doctrine have gotten? Nowhere.

How many people would have been spared because of that? How many people are going to hell because we are not reaching them?

Would God reach them if He could? Yes. Unfortunately, you are the only thing He has to work with.

If one of those guys was in town, everybody would walk on eggshells. They would get accountants and straighten their books up real quick.

What happened to Hymenaeus and Alexander? Paul said they had turned aside to vain jangling. They desired to be teachers of the law. They were destroying the foundation of the church. Paul said, in a manner of speaking, while having a cup of tea one day, "I turned them over to Satan so they would learn not to blaspheme."

I am thinking, You what?

I particularly like the one in 1 Corinthians who had his father's wife. I love the way Paul said, "A little leaven leaveneth the whole lump."

We thought God just got real mad because of the adultery. If it were not spreading through the church, He would have just dealt with that guy. But when Paul said little leaven leavens the whole lump, he meant the church was weak and in danger of receiving that lifestyle as okay.

So he says, "I am with you in my spirit." Paul did not kind of translate there. He said, "I am able to make a judgment from here because I am with you and I understand it. Turn this man over to Satan for the destruction of his flesh, that his spirit might be saved in the day of the Lord."

Paul had instantaneous judgment on Paphos. The deputy wanted to hear the gospel, so they sent for Paul and Barnabas. There was a Jewish sorcerer by the name of Bar-Jesus who withstood Paul. Paul said, "How about being blind for a season? Would you like that?"

It was a season, so he would come out of it. Someone had to lead him away by the hand. But guess what? The deputy was born again.

This sounds rough. I know. But one thing God is doing is this: when He can find what He needs, the fullness of many of those things is going to come back to the foundation of the church.

You can bet this about God: when it comes to judgment and those kinds of things, the feeble attempts preachers have made are usually for their own self-exaltation. That is not the kind of mercy that rejoices against judgment and qualifies.

Ananias and Sapphira are a mystery. When is the last time you heard it preached on in your lifetime? When is the last time you heard a line-upon-line preacher go through Acts 5? Have you ever done it?

Not me. I just kind of sped through it.

"Do not go to that fifth chapter. I want to read about them again. I am already scared."

How many know that instantaneous judgment, if it were in place in the right hands, would prevent more people from going to hell than not?

So I am going to warm up to this. We will begin at the first verse. This is the first six pages of the teaching that is going to be interneted, whatever you call it.

Brother Tim, one of the most frightening accounts in the whole New Testament is what happened to Ananias and Sapphira. What makes this so scary is that you and I know ministries guilty of exactly the same kinds of things, yet they seem to have suffered no particular judgment themselves.

If that is not enough, Ananias and Sapphira were not exactly ministers, but part of the congregation itself.

The verses that carry the account of what happened to Ananias and Sapphira are probably one of the worst nightmares for teachers who love to teach the books of the Bible line upon line, verse by verse. For those who love to teach subjects, Ananias and Sapphira is a subject often avoided.

So let us take a look at these controversial verses for a moment, Acts 5:1-11:

But a certain man named Ananias, with Sapphira his wife, sold a possession,  
And kept back part of the price, his wife also being privy to it, and brought a certain part, and laid it at the apostles' feet.  
But Peter said, Ananias, why hath Satan filled thine heart to lie to the Holy Ghost, and to keep back part of the price of the land?  
Whiles it remained, was it not thine own? and after it was sold, was it not in thine own power?  
why hast thou conceived this thing in thine heart? thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God.  
And Ananias hearing these words fell down, and gave up the ghost...

And great fear came on all of them who handed out envelopes on television.

No, wait a minute. Let me get it now.

And the young men arose, wound him up, and carried him out, and buried him.

Can you just see what kind of youth group that was? "What do you do?" "We carry people out."

They wrapped him up in a burial sheet, carried him out, and buried him.

And it was about the space of three hours after, when his wife, not knowing what was done, came in.

And Peter answered unto her, Tell me whether ye sold the land for so much?

And she said, Yea, for so much.

Then Peter said unto her, How is it that ye have agreed together to tempt the Spirit of the Lord?

behold, the feet of them which have buried thy husband are at the door, and shall carry thee out.

Then fell she down straightway at his feet, and yielded up the ghost:

and the young men came in, and found her dead, and, carrying her forth, buried her by her husband.

And great fear came upon all the church, and upon as many as heard these things.

No wonder.

Notice:

And by the hands of the apostles were many signs and wonders wrought among the people; and they were all with one accord in Solomon's porch.

And of the rest durst no man join himself to them: but the people magnified them.

Even though the people were magnifying that inner core, after that judgment took place there were a lot of people who did not want to join themselves to the inner core anymore, the ones who were sold out.

Hello, Prayer Center.

And believers were the more added to the Lord, multitudes both of men and women.

Insomuch that they brought forth the sick into the streets, and laid them on beds and couches,

that at the least the shadow of Peter passing by might overshadow some of them.

There came also a multitude out of the cities round about unto Jerusalem, bringing sick folks,

and them which were vexed with unclean spirits: and they were healed every one.

How many? Come on, people, this is not a one-time thing. I do not remember seeing that, nor any writings outside of the Bible where that happened. So you have to admit the mantle was at its fullness.

Two things were at their fullness: these men counted nothing their own, and the mantle was at its fullness. Because those were at their fullness, another thing was at its fullness that we understand very little about: the instantaneous judgment spoken by Peter and later many times by Paul, and documented.

The one thing we wanted to clear up when we got to this point is this: because the judgment was instantaneous does not mean that when they gave up the ghost, they did not go to heaven.

How many preachers do you think you are going to have in heaven if they did not make it?

Just because the judgment was instantaneous does not mean they did not go to heaven. In fact, they did. Those are the Scriptures I wanted to major on tonight, the ones that prove they did.

What makes it so scary is that it was instantaneous.

Hymenaeus and Alexander were turned over so they would learn not to blaspheme. I think when they learned their lesson, they wanted the devil to leave them alone or they would die.

The man Paul turned over to the devil for the destruction of his flesh, that his spirit might be saved in the day of the Lord, probably had some horrible disease or something come on him. He probably repented and was made right with God before he died. But he has been in heaven a couple of thousand years.

Would you rather have been turned over than been in hell for two thousand years?

Turn me over. Get me out of this mess.

This instantaneous kind of judgment scares us. It happened, and it had to do with the foundation of the church. The reason it happened is because God could find what He needed to do it with.

To tell you the truth, God would probably search the whole planet, and I would be shocked if He found one person at this point that He could use exactly like that. But I do know that the revival of doctrine, of truth, and the information being made available through the power of the Holy Spirit means people are going to take their places in the body again.

Not because God just sovereignly thought, "We will do this now," but because people heard truth and began to transform into something He could use.

Does it comfort you to know that Ananias and Sapphira are in heaven?

If that does not comfort you, how about people you know?

I thank God for the day I discovered that He could not love me any more, that His love was maxed at the cross. If God had another ounce of love, all deity could connive for a billion years and not come up with another ounce of love that was not manifested at the cross.

My glory yesterday is when I found out how to stop and start receiving the love He has always loved me with.

The more it changes me, the more I get to look over Him and understand why He does things the way He does. He is not at all like what most preachers have made Him out to be.

It did not surprise me to find out Ananias and Sapphira did not go to hell. It did not surprise me. Hallelujah.

Like most preachers, Tim, I have an excellent set of Greek books to access the original language. Unfortunately, sometimes the Greek version tells the story just as generically as the King James and gives no particular insight into why judgment would come on Ananias and Sapphira so suddenly over something most preachers would esteem trivial and insignificant, such as lying.

Most commentators console themselves with words like "special acts of God," not knowing how to reconcile what happened to Ananias and Sapphira with the morals of the modern-day church.

The general conclusion of most commentaries is that they were set forth as some kind of special example, a sort of one-time thing. But if that is the case, what have we learned?

Greed among ministers is at an all-time high. There seems to be no fear among a growing number of preachers who represent the gospel. They seem to think a sheep's life will rise or fall according to what they are giving into their ministries.

Let us go to 1 Corinthians 3.

Is anybody having a good time? Me too.

I love judgment, so we will get into it a little more as time goes by, after we establish the fact that they are in heaven.

Amen.

How many would think that would be the first thing you would want to know?

If you are going, "Served them right," you have a wrong spirit.

Kick in around verse 9. Paul wanted to speak to them as spiritual, but he could not because they were not able to bear it. He gives an order here:

For we are labourers together with God: ye are God's husbandry, ye are God's building.

He switches from husbandry to building and stays on the building from then on. He says:

According to the grace of God which is given unto me, as a wise masterbuilder, I have laid the foundation,

and another buildeth thereon.

But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon.

For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ.

Each one of you is a lively stone in the building being laid on the foundation of what Paul preached, which is Jesus Christ crucified. Every one of your lives is making a contribution as a lively stone in that building. That is why he gives this warning:

Now if any man build upon this foundation gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, stubble;  
Every man's work shall be made manifest: for the day shall declare it,  
because it shall be revealed by fire;  
and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is.  
If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward.  
If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss:  
but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire.

I am glad that the final judgment follows us home. That day shall declare it.

Paul laid the foundation, and you come along saying, "I am a teacher," so you are a lively stone in the building of God. You are laying upon that foundation and about to make a contribution to the whole work. Your whole ministry will represent something.

If you are an evangelist laid upon that foundation, and you start teaching, "Everybody is already saved," what do you think will happen when a refiner's fire hits everything you did? What does fire do to gold? It purifies it and burns the dross out.

If you made no contribution whatsoever that can be esteemed as of Him, it will all burn. But if you are born again, you will be saved as by fire. You may not have a reward, but you are saved.

So are you telling me He sent Ananias and Sapphira to hell because they altered an offering and lied about it?

Here is a thought: if the trash is going to be burned in that day of trying by fire, do you think He can bless offerings that support the construction of trash?

If it is going to be burned there, do you think He is the One who built it?

"But they were so sincere."

It was still trash.

Unfortunately with media, it will spread the devil's gospel as fast as God's. When we were on foot, the devil had his men and God had His. Now that we are in every living room, the devil has his and we have ours. Same old war. We just have to trump theirs with everything He has.

Amen.

If everything you constructed was burned by that refiner's fire and the only thing left was salvation, then tell me Ananias and Sapphira did not make it.



What scared us was the mantle we did not understand, the instantaneous judgment that took place on the spot. If they had died slowly for being in error, you would have accepted that they were in heaven. "Oh, they made it okay. They just would not listen to God."

Hallelujah.

Verse 15 again:

If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss:  
but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire.

The final act of mercy is that all that stuff is burned away, and salvation holds because you believed He saved you and you were born again.

Verse 16 says:

Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?  
If any man defile the temple of God, him shall God destroy;  
for the temple of God is holy, which temple ye are.

In holiness circles, they always preached that about smoking: "Know ye not that you are God's temple, and the Spirit dwells in you? If you destroy this temple, God will destroy you." So we preached smoking, drinking, chewing. That is how illuminated we were.

I used to make those big loggers mad in the break shack. I did not have much wisdom.

They said, "You mean smoking will send us to hell?"

I said, "Maybe not, but it makes you smell like you have been there."

He said, "You are God's temple, and if you defile it, him will God destroy." But he was not talking about this physical temple singularly, although it is included. He was talking first about Paul laying the foundation, which is none other than Jesus Christ crucified, and then you as lively stones making your contribution, whatever it is and whatever your calling is.

The one who destroys the temple is the person who destroys the foundation and takes Jesus crucified out of it. Him will God destroy because he removed salvation.

But you can have a lot of trash, a lot of wrong believing, a lot of wrong teaching, a lot of lying, and all that kind of stuff going on. It will all be burned. But if you love Jesus and are born again, He will burn that up, and you shall be saved, yet so as by fire.

So do not tell me Ananias and Sapphira went to hell.

God did for the early church what He would do anytime now: straighten her foundation up if He had the people He could use. But they are on their way.

How do you know? Because of the revival of truth. We are going to find our way back.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

I am so glad there are no limits on the power. What have you guys been saying? Everyone, every time, no limits on the power.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

There will be such demonstrations on a city-wide level that will strike that same kind of fear in their hearts: "My God, He is here. We had better do something about our lives."

They have already looked at what we have, basically, as the church world, and the sinner is not afraid. But you turn God loose, and there will be godly fear walking up and down the streets.

We are going to do it, are we not?

Hallelujah. We are going to do it.